

are. And there is, I think, a narrative that links all those events together. Not a detailed account. But a story of how things fit together.

Since this is an attempt to link the big events together, it leaves out many details of what happened during this period. I'm likely to agree with anyone who points out what I've missed. The goal here is not to describe every play; it's to look at how one game influenced the next.

Here's how the modern consumer got here.

1. August, 1945. World War II ends.

Japan surrendering was "The Happiest Day in American History," *The New York Times* wrote.

But there's the saying, "History is just one damn thing after another."

The joy of the war ending was quickly met with the question, "What happens now?"

Sixteen million Americans—11% of the population—served in the war. About eight million were overseas at the end. Their average age was 23. Within 18 months all but 1.5 million of them would be home and out of uniform.

And then what?

What were they going to do next?

Where were they going to work?

Where were they going to live?

Those were the most important questions of the day, for two reasons. One, no one knew the answers. Two, if they couldn't be answered quickly, the most likely scenario—in the eyes of many economists—was that the economy would slip back into the depths of the Great Depression.

Three forces had built up during the war:

1. Housing construction ground to a halt, as virtually all production capacity was shifted to building war supplies. Fewer than 12,000 homes per month were built in 1943, equivalent to less than one new